

This essay will explore the construction of identity through consumption by analysing the global image of the modern girl in the inter war period. The decision to explore the idea of consumption through the Modern Girl was because, “perhaps like no other figure of the twentieth century, [she] reveals the complexity of global economic and cultural processes.” (Weinbaum et al., 2008). Appearing globally in the 1920s and 1930s, the Modern Girl symbolised a departure from traditional female roles through specific commodities and explicit eroticism (Weinbaum et al., 2008). She was characterised as having short hair, wearing loose clothing, and engaging in masculine activities such as smoking and dancing. By examining the interplay between consumption and identity construction, this analysis will delve into the ways in which women navigated their societal roles—whether they were genuinely living liberated lives or merely buying into a pre-packaged lifestyle.

The socio-economic changes following World War I created fertile ground for the emergence of the Modern Girl. The war had disrupted traditional gender roles, as women took on jobs and responsibilities that had long been those of the men. The return to peacetime did not fully reverse these changes; instead, many women continued to seek independence and new social freedoms. Figure 1, exemplifies the characterisation of the modern girl



Figure 1: Edith Lee smokes a cigarette on the 'Torches for Freedom' march, New York, 1929

and this essay will focus on the consumption cigarettes and her interaction with beauty standards in particular the bobbed hair. Figure 1 is an example of an American woman however, in a global context Modern Girls were known as flappers, garconnes, moga, modern xiaojie, schoolgirls, kallege ladki, vamps and Neue Frauen. . (Weinbaum, A.E. Thomas et al ,2008) The sentiment of interwar society was that the “modern girl was a bonding womanhood and her roles as wife, daughter, and mother. (Weinbaum, A.E. Thomas et al ,2008) However as this essay will argue “modern girl was little more than an image, a hollow product of clever advertising campaigns in the new commodity culture” (Weinbaum, A.E. Thomas et al ,2008)

The modern girl was known as a smoker, it was one of her identifiable consumer goods. In this interwar period, smoking was associated with the image of the modern girl in France, South Africa, India, and Japan. However, smoking does not make a woman more liberated in-fact women smoking was the direct result and aim of Edward Bernays and Lucky strike. In 1929, the president of the American Tobacco Corporation asked Bernays to find a way to break the taboo against women smoking as he felt they were losing half their market. A loss of half of their market meant a loss of half of their profits. Bernays then sought the counsel of psycho-analyst AA Brill who advised Bernays to connect the idea of smoking to the idea of challenging male power. Bernays made cigarettes a symbol of female freedom and of democracy with his torches of freedom campaign. He hired upper-class suffragettes to be photographed smoking and for the image to be printed with the phrase “torches of freedom” as can be seen in figure 1. The image invoked the statue of liberty a signal of American democracy and freedom worldwide. He had solidified the idea that women smoking was powerful and independent. The idea that women smoking made them freer was irrational, but it made them feel more independent. (Adam Curtis, 2002) “Consumerism is an obscene fetish. We buy things not because we need them, but because they are an emotional turn-on” (Francombe, A., 2024) This feeling did not improve material conditions of women but it did increase profits for the company's in the

American tobacco company. (Adam Curtis, 2002) In 1927 a journalist wrote “a change has come over our democracy. It is consumption. The US citizen is first importance to his country is no longer that of citizen it is that of consumer.” (Adam Curtis, 2002) . Smoking didn’t make women more liberated it simply made them consumers.

This is clear, as by 1929 women were still second-class citizens globally. In the United States, although they had secured the vote in 1920 many African American women were still unable to vote, due to the threat of lynching, the grandfather clause, poll taxes and literacy tests. Furthermore, American women were not treated as equals in wider society an example being that women were not guaranteed the right to loans or bank accounts until 1974. This is true also in France. La Garçonne, popularised by Victor Margueritte's novel "La Garçonne" (1922), was characterised by her androgynous appearance and rejection of conventional femininity. La Garçonne adopted men's clothing styles, short haircuts, and a lifestyle that emphasised independence and modernity and by extent masculinity. La garconne was also a smoker, however, it was not until 1944 that french women were given the right to vote. In present day France, muslim women are not allowed to wear a hijabs or abayas. The modern girl symbolised a freedom that has yet to be granted to all women suggesting that the modern girl was not a women living life but a consumer. The modern girl did not champion these rights of women she was merely associated with them.

So I kept arguing with my mother until she said one day ‘if you want, go have it cut’ and apparently she didn’t mean what she said but I took her at her face value and I had my hair cut and believe you me all hell broke loose there is not other way to put it. (Internet Archive,1985)

Above is a quote of a woman recounting her days as a flapper, she expresses a sentiment of many 'modern girls' which was to be unlike their mothers. An expression of this rebellion against their mothers was short hair. This short, bobbed hair became synonymous with the modern girl globally. This hairstyle was part of a new "reconsideration of femininity" (Zdanthy, S.,1997) It was perceived as a drastic and unhealthy departure from the elaborate hairstyle of the earlier generation. Cropped hair was not as groundbreaking. In fact Paul Poiret cut his models hair for his 1908 collection; Irne castle was also known for her short hair and The Great Antoine "had delivered his famous coupe à la Jeanne d'Arc to the actress Eve Lavalière in 1909" (Zdanthy, S.,1997) There are many other examples of women with shorter and hair and "Emile Long, dean of Parisian coiffeurs, reporting on the sumptuous "Victory Balls" of 1919, noted that shorter styles were already common among fashionable young ladies." (Zdanthy, S.,1997) However, the shift in public outrage happened when this style was adopted not just by fashionable upper-class women but on mass amongst all classes. This hair cut was not the 'cultural revolution' it seemed as it was not freeing women, as while their "hair became shorter it did not become simpler or cheaper. Quite the contrary: cheveux courts required constant attention and frequent trips to the beauty parlour. Women consequently began to spend more and more money on their hair." (Zdanthy, S.,1997) So although as the woman recounting her days as flapper felt she was liberating herself from the constraints of beauty that her mother's generation had endured. She was still subscribed to beauty standards that expected her to spend more money and attention on her looks. Far more than her male counterpart. Despite Pierre Drieu la Rochelle's despair in the 1920s that there were "no longer sexes" (Roberts, M.L.,1992) women were still conforming to a system that expected them to buy into beauty in the same way their mothers had done before the First World War.

The conversation of beauty and hair has a further complexity for black women. In America, the fact that bobbed hair and the modern girl look was technically accessible to all, anyone can cut

their hair short, was weaponised and “strategically deployed to contest Jim Crow racial hierarchies that were buttressed by de jure and de facto racial segregation.” (Weinbaum et al., 2008). The argument being that beauty standards were now democratic, although as we know it was not a democracy for all. The idea that beauty standards were now democratic was simply a marketing ploy, as they continued to remain very rigid, they were the same the modern girl’s mothers. As can be seen in figure 2 many companies utilised the modern girl and the conception of her being a reflection, product and champion of a democratic society to sell products. In figure 2, Pompei suggests that “a Modern Girl may become an American among other Americans through commodity consumption”, (Weinbaum et al., 2008) she may buy her way into the melting pot.

Furthermore, “such ads indicate to consumers which immigrant groups have gained the status of whiteness. Through occlusion or non-representation of other groups they also indicate who is deemed inassimilable within the representational strategies of the advertisements as within the nation at large.” (Weinbaum et al., 2008).

Blackness was considered inadmissible and “the racist



Figure 2. An advertisement in U.S. Ladies Home Journal (1928) for Pompeian makeup, catering expressly to white ethnics from Southern and Eastern Europe, America's so - called " in - between s.

ideologies of social Darwinism were quite effectively disseminated through white beauty and cosmetics advertisements, packaging, and procedures.” (Weinbaum et al., 2008). The black female consumer was targeted with “before and after” ads for products like Black No More and Kink No More, in which a “dark skinned, woolly haired” primitive was transformed into a refined and cultivated “high class” and physically “whiter” lady.” (Weinbaum et al., 2008). Be that through Madam CJ walkers Hair relaxers or the many skin whiteners available. Signifying that the modern girl was in reality a continuation of the established hierarchies. Social Darwinism was used globally as a marketing tool to capture the black consumer. In South Africa “Bantu World ad featuring a line drawing of a bobbed hair and bare shouldered black Modern Girl gazing into a handheld mirror promises readers an improved appearance through use of Apex hair products and skin bleach” (Weinbaum et al., 2008). Throughout the interwar period cosmetic companies advertise budgets were especially high and it is clear that they played a central and global role in the mediation of the modern girl aesthetic and her engagement with commodities. (Weinbaum et al., 2008). The modern was not simply living life she was buying a lifestyle. A lifestyle that was underpinned by the same hierarchies that she claimed to rebel against.

The modern girl “is the child of capitalism and just like the system that spawned it it is both a source of pleasure and pain, expression and exploitation” (Francombe, A., 2024) The modern girl was buying a lifestyle she did not fundamentally challenge the hierarchies that she was rebelling against. In fact she actively engaged with it. Her hair was short, her clothes were loose, she danced and smoked but ultimately she stood for just an aesthetic change. This change in aesthetic may have made her feel freer but her newfound feelings perpetuated the system that she had felt subjugated by.

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Images

Figure 1: Mostegel, I. (2019.) Edith Lee smokes a cigarette on the 'Torches for Freedom' march, New York, 1929. Available at: <https://www.historytoday.com/miscellanies/original-influencer>

Figure 2: Weinbaum, A.E. Thomas, L.M. Ramamurthy, P. Poiger, U.G. Dong, M.Y. and Barlow, T. (2008) "The Modern Girl Around the World: Consumption, Modernity, and Globalization" <https://books.google.co.uk/books?id=BxQxkiBqXrsC&lpg=PP1&pg=PP1#v=onepage&q&f=false>